

James McIntosh.
Press Release plus interview transcript.

Press Release.

The Food We Produce In Northern Ireland Is Worth Shouting About.

Belfast. February 13th, 2015. World award-winning cookery presenter and good food evangelist James McIntosh has published a paper about marketing the food and drink products of Northern Ireland.

"Northern Ireland has a new found confidence in artisanal food from many small producers across the province," says McIntosh. "I firmly believe that food from Northern Ireland is some of the best in the world and is central to the Northern Irish economy for both tourism and export"

McIntosh is better known in China than he is in his home town of Tandragee. He has presented cookery programs to a billion people and had an award-winning series on China TV called 'Food Adventures on the Silk Road'.

Now McIntosh believes that Northern Ireland is ready to put itself on the world map for the quality of its food and drink. "I grew up on a farm in Tandragee," McIntosh says, "so I know about the passion our food producers put into their products."

In February 2015, McIntosh will be making a presentation titled 'Honest Food' at the Belfast Focus on Food event. The presentation, which he has also given to the Northern Irish Government, is also available on the website address below and will be of interest to food producers throughout Northern Ireland.

To download the 'Honest Food™' presentation free of charge, please visit:

www.jamesmcintosh.co.uk/ni

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Contact details.
Phone: 07572 430 050
Email: james@jamesmcintosh.co.uk

Note to editors: An interview transcript is also included.

Interview Transcript.

"Northern Ireland has a new found confidence in artisanal food from many small producers across the province. I firmly believe that food from home is some of the best in the world and is central to the Northern Irish economy for both tourism and export"

Q: Having spent a significant amount of time working in the international market you must have gained a very different perspective of the local food industry. How has it changed in recent years? Is N. Ireland gaining more of a foothold in the food tourism market?

A: Yes is my feeling, but the key markers surely are with the airlines. Belfast's George Best City Airport reporting passenger numbers are up 12% over the previous year and announcements that new airlines are wanting to come to Northern Ireland can only increase passenger numbers. I can't explain the pride I felt when flying to China a few weeks ago and read in the British Airways Highlife magazine that Belfast was listed as one of the great new destinations for food. Coupled with the fact that we are winning more food awards for our produce compared to any other part of the UK I would say an emphatic 'yes'.

Q: What would you consider to be the main challenges faced by those working in the local food industry today?

A: I like to take the approach to be thankful for what we have first and then build from there up. Food NI and Invest NI are doing great work for the food industry at home. Their commitment to NI is impressive. Tourism Northern Ireland actively encourage food tourism and have produced a legacy of research with practical suggestions on how to use this to our benefit. All of the hard work has been done. The main challenge like any business it to write a business plan that is realistic for growth to secure a stable and financially viable business.

Q: How can these issues be addressed?

A: I produced a document that I have presented to many key opinion formers about food and tourism, including the Tourism Northern Ireland and Invest NI. You can download it for free at www.jamesmcintosh.co.uk/ni. It outlines how we could capitalise on Global Food media in three key areas:

1. Food and Tourism
2. Our Food Status Globally
3. Global Media Development

These points are taken from a starting realisation that our food in NI represents our new confidence. As a farming and food producing nation good food is what we know and it's all part of our DNA. How many of us are more than one degree of separation

away from the food industry? How many of our grand parents did not grow up on farms? So wholesome food is in our blood, and if we embrace this as our food being the business plan of Northern Ireland and look at our past as being behind us and seeing the future is on our plate ... then we can welcome the world to Northern Ireland.

I have seen many times at international events how food removes borders. We are all the same: black and white, gay and straight, Protestant and Catholic, Muslim and Christian ... we all do the same things when we eat. Eating together gives us a time when we can talk, share and learn from each other. I have seen Greeks and Turks, Israelis and Palestinians, Arabic Sheiks and Nigerian Christians talk to each other with mutual respect about food. Food tells our story as a people. Learning these stories from other nations helps us to understand each other and at that point we realise we are all the same.

It's quite a mission, but my goal is to change what Wikipedia says about Northern Ireland. Instead of focusing on our 'troubles', wouldn't it be great if writers focused on our successes ... starting with our world leading food status.

Q: What are N. Ireland's unique selling points in terms of the global market?

A: The French talk about '*terroirs*', a combination of climate, soil and other factors for growing food. We have this. We have a micro climate, fertile lands, lots of rain and the ancestral knowledge to grow fantastic food. Not to forget we have some of the strictest farm tractability schemes in the world. We may take it for granted but our landscape is stunning, our hospitality is natural. I have travelled to over 40 countries presenting food TV and writing cookery books, I have concluded that the best is my home, Northern Ireland.

Q: From your own experience, what is the best advice you could give anyone launching a new food product/venture?

A: Produce the marketing and distribution plan before developing the product! Marketing is key to how a product will sell, and will also dictate the life of your product through increased revenue with brand extensions. Distribution is probably the most important part of any food product. Be proud of our heritage and label your products as coming from Northern Ireland as this will add benefit to us all. China, Thailand, France and Italy are all famed for their food. Northern Ireland is not yet on the global food radar, so with clever marketing and making the right noise at the right time to the right media we can work together as Team Northern Ireland.

Contact:

www.jamesmcintosh.co.uk

@jamesmcintosh

James has presented his message to the Northern Irish government. To download

James' free strategy paper on how we make Northern Ireland a place of world tourism and a food 'centre of excellence', please visit www.jamesmcintosh.co.uk/ni